

you tend to operate by this philosophy, think of this perspective: have you ever seen a bird sitting on a rock waiting for worms to come wandering by? Hardly so; every bird I've ever seen was up earlier than you and me, turning over rocks looking for worms.

If you find that your expenses exceed your income, you must do one of two things: either cut down on your expenses or increase your income (or some combination thereof). If you can't figure a way to do it BEFORE you're married, let me assure you, it's not going to be easier to do it AFTER you're married. Many couples think they can adjust after marriage, and end up in debt. Unfortunately, many also end up in divorce court, Christians included—something none of them set out to do.

I have never counseled a single couple who said, "Larry, we just wanted to share with you our five-year goal. Five years ago when we got married, we set out to get so miserably into debt that I can't stand my wife and she can't stand me. We don't ever pray together and we don't ever go to church anymore, but we are right where we wanted to be." No couple wants that. Do you know what they say? "How in the world did this happen? How did we let ourselves get into a mess like this? What can we do to get out of it?" The best thing that you can do is never let it happen in the first place.

A BALANCED BUDGET

Most couples have some gaping holes in their budgets. These holes are budget categories that have been excluded, such as clothing, entertainment, vacations, et cetera. That's fine if you're never going to need those things. But most of us do, and to leave them out makes the budget look good, but deceptively so.

Most initial budgets have no allocation for clothing. When asked about it, most Christian couples respond, "We're going to trust God for our clothes." I usually then inquire, "Does that mean that you're going to do without them if God doesn't provide?" Obviously, that's not exactly what they meant. Is it